

Benny Marshall says— Williams' blast at the military better unsaid



That was a great stroke good old Ted Williams struck for Johnny Podres.

Can't you just hear Brooklyn John next time he meets up with the Thumper? . . .

"Gee, Ted, thanks. That was swell of you, telling off those draft boards and all that."

The only catch . . . it might be a while before Podres and Williams meet again. The Red Sox slugger will be one place, the Dodger pitcher another, in khaki.

The ending was inevitable once the Podres case was pushed out in the bright limelight by Williams' blast at the "gutless" military for its audacity in summoning young John "because he's a baseball star."

The 30 to 50-day wait which was to have been Podres' was, of a sudden, reduced to right now. . . . "Gee, Ted, thanks."

THEN THERE WAS a sports writer, interviewing Birdie Tebbets, the Cincinnati manager, down in Florida . . . and Birdie had a beef, too.

It appeared unfair to him that big leaguers, whose careers are short, should be compelled to pay high income taxes while they're hitting the big money.

This, to say the least, was a novel approach to that situation.

Out at the Marshall Manor, all hands are prepared to trade, even-up, for any and all income tax problems now suffered by all overburdened athletes in the \$25,000-a-year class.

All of such (including the Williams proposal to draft baseball players only for off-season service in peace-time) serve only to point up sadly once more the fact that some big league baseball men wind up with an exaggerated idea of their own importance.

What does it, of course, is the adulation of millions of fans, and an unending stream of publicity (free, of course). It's human enough for a man told often enough that he's sort of a super-fellow maybe to start believing.

Williams, completely disdainful, always, of the fans who've made his baseball-bitting ability into the big, big payoff . . . Williams, who served his nation nobly in two wars . . . he'd just be better off most of the time if he kept his famous mouth closed.

That way his foot wouldn't be in it so much.

THE WILLIAMS TYPE isn't confined to the major leagues. . . . You'll find it down in the minors, too.

Jack Cassini, the Memphis manager who'll be enlivening our Summer nights again soon, never led the American League in batting . . . but he's a gentleman who thinks that the best greeting, most times, is a snarl.

Happily, however, there's another school represented down here by such as the Barons' Phil Page; by Mayo Smith before him; by Mike Higgins, Red Marion and Fred Walters.

It's a pleasure to do business with a smiling professional like Andy Cohen of New Orleans, and not on the sports-writing level alone. . . . Andrew's a man who can look at the stands and see the side that bread's buttered on.

And the great guys in the majors who're champions all the way . . . Phil Rizzuto, Stan Musial, Walt Dropo, Joe Collins, Yogi Berra, Gil Hodges, Alex Grammas of our town, and Frank House, too; Willard Nixon, Paul Richards, Luman Harris, Casey Stengel, on and on and on. The list is long . . . long enough to keep this fan convinced that most of the folks around the top still are top-flighters.

AWARENESS OF THE customer has not always been a distinguishing characteristic of baseball, on the Williams player level or up above.

But there again there's a front office man like Eddie Glennon available for purposes of rebuttal.

It is not likely that everybody loves the Baron head man. It doesn't come out that way, ever. . . . But there never has been, in the business of baseball, an executive more keenly attuned to the fact that the ticket buyer's interest is paramount.

The ball park that Al DeMent and Albert Belcher own is operated, always, on a "Fans First" basis.

A lesson there that a lot of other baseball men haven't yet learned. . . . But they had best be studying.



JOHNNY PODRES
. . . "Gee, thanks"



PHIL PAGE
. . . Another kind